

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*The Gospel of Life ~
The Gospel According to Jane Goodall*

26 October 2025



*Jane Goodall and Flint
Photo by Hugo von Lawick, 1965
Kigoma, Tanzania*

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
Telephone 213.385.1341 – www.FCCLA.org

Childcare & Children's Programming at First Church

FCCLA offers childcare and children's programming during service for all ages — from infants through youth. For more information or to register your child, please stop by the First Kids First check-in table in the entrance to the Cathedral, or follow the signs in the hallway through the middle doors of the Sanctuary.

The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions...

We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in-Residence

Improvisation on TALLIS' CANNON and AZMON

Variations on B-A-C-H (Christoph Bull)

Driver without a carriage (Philip Glass) and Improvisation

Domine Deus from *The Mass* (Patrick Cassidy, adapted for Organ Solo) and Improvisation

Toccatina and Fugue in D minor (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Sarah Fuhrmeister & Rev. Lehman

We open now to the mystery of Life, to the Holy One and Holy Oneness,
infinitely greater than words can express, and yet the Heart of our hearts,
and the Mind of our minds,
and whose love for us and all creation exceeds our capacity to imagine.

We open now to the mystery of Life, to the Holy Oneness,
the web of life that holds all beings in intimate embrace,
making it possible to distinguish but never disconnect
any part from the whole, or the whole from the parts,
making us kin in the kin-dom of life.

We open now to the mystery of Life, knowing this adventure
to be a journey back to the present source –
discovered at our own depths – and a forward journey
toward a new heaven and a new earth,
which is being born through us, and know above all and below all
that this is not a path to God, but a path in God.

This morning, we celebrate this great adventure together!

Please stand as you are able, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

O for a World

AZMON

O for a world where everyone respects each other's ways,
where love is lived and all is done with justice and with praise.

O for a world where goods are shared and misery relieved,
Where truth is spoken, children spared, equality achieved.

We welcome one world family and struggle with each choice
That opens us to unity and gives our vision voice.

The poor are rich, the weak are strong, the foolish ones are wise.
Tell all who mourn, outcasts belong, who perishes will rise.

O for a world preparing for God's glorious reign of peace,
Where time and tears will be no more, and all but love will cease.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

*Eternal Mystery, Heaven's Presence,
Stillest Breath, and Deepest Sigh,
we open our hearts
to your presence,
and to the presence of who we are
in this place.*

Each of us brings life to this day's possibilities.
We bring hope or despair,
eagerness or malaise,
joy or sorrow,
and with these things – we come to worship.

*May the beauty of life's fullness unfold in our hearts
that we may loosen
the grip of the mundane in our lives.*

May the richness of mystery unfold in our minds
that we may let go of our need for proof.
May the possibility of newness and light
be present to us
that we may unfold the wings of our faith
and soar into the world changed by
these mysterious possibilities.

*May we see in this time of worship,
the collective beauty of the world
and the miracle of your presence,
and of our presence, in it.* [rexhunt]
Amen and Amen!

***Introit**

"Joy and Elation"

CYNTHIA DOBRINSKI

Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Director*, Meredith Chin, *Flute*

***The Lord's Prayer**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

*O Divine Power of Creation
hallowed be your name,
the mystery of your grace be with us.*

*Give us this day our nourishment
for both body and the soul
and forgive our shortcomings
as we forgive the shortcomings of those around us.*

*Strengthen us in the ways of wisdom
and strengthen our spirit when confronted with evil.
For you are the glory and the power
of all that is seen and unseen
for ever and ever.
Amen and Amen!*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

May our time together renew our hope.
May the stories we share refresh our courage.
May the songs we sing lift our spirits.
May the words we speak invigorate us.
May the touch of hands, the sound of laughter,
the sight of faces new and familiar,
restore us in faith. [codame]

On this day,
we give thanks for the opportunity we have to gather and celebrate this day.
May we be surrounded with a very real sense
of the presentness of the Source and Sustainer of all that exists
as we spend this time together.

May the peace of God inspire you, challenge you,
and be with you on this day.
And also with you.

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition *from the Book of Job, chapter 12*

Sarah Fuhrmeister

This is the wisdom of the ancestors.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Eternal God of promise and hope,
enter our lives with your loving power;
grant to each of us gathered in this sacred time,
an exuberance for life
and a desire to share the love of the Christ.

On this day, we pray that many of the things
we are prone to disbelieve -
will be raised up as possibilities...

By the power of the Christ who lives within us,
may we be empowered:
to exist in harmony and balance with the natural world,
to care passionately for all the creatures of the earth,
to share the good earth in peace as children of humanity,
to work for the building of your dream for us all,
and to give thanks to you on this day, and every day,
as our hearts are filled with love and joy,
even in the midst of our unknowing.

In this precious moment, let our gratitude for life,
burst forth like laughter in this time together.
And, may our gratitude on this day grow within us
for all we have experienced in this, our sacred time and place.

Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"Jesu, Joy of Our Desiring"
Cathedral Choir

J.S. BACH

Sermon

The Gospel According to Jane Goodall

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Fregin

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

At this table we give thanks for
justice, love, peace and freedom.

*At this table we give thanks for friends and strangers
together in community in this safe place...*

At this table...

*May the passion for life as seen in Jesus,
and in the lives and struggles of many other
committed and faithful people then and now,
enable us to dare and to dream and to risk...*

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Communion Music

"Homenaje, Le Tombeau de Debussy"

"Garoto (Choro)"

Michel von Loh, *Guitar*

MANUEL DE FALLA

ANTÔNIO CARLOS JOBIM

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Lehman

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"Guitarra dímelo tú"

ATAHUALPA YUPANQUI

*"If I ask the world, the world will deceive me. Why have people given up
on each other, on the earth? How long will they forget? Guitar, you tell me."*

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,

let the Creator's praise arise!

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Your name shall sound and praises soar

till suns shall rise and set no more.

Alleluia! Alleluia!

Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!

[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Sarah Fuhrmeister

Creator God, you prepare a new way in the wilderness
and your grace waters the desert.

Even in the midst of our brokenness
you call us to co-create our future with you.

Help us in the days ahead to recognize your hand
working miracles beyond our imagining.
And then, O God, open our hearts to be transformed
by the new thing you are doing,
so that our lives may proclaim
the extravagance of your love for all,
and its presence in Jesus the Christ.

For this and so much more,
we ask, and we give thanks, O God.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

The God we worship is never confined to this holy place.
So go and travel with the God who is found
in ordinary and surprising places.

*We go in faith to live in joyous freedom,
to play in the creation, and to drink deeply
of the gracious cup of life.* [DMcRae-McMahon]

May the mystery of God be found along the road
you travel.
May the wonder of the costly love of Jesus embrace you.
And may the Spirit bless and keep you, always.

May it be so.
May it be so for all us!

Choral Response

"Iona Alleluia"
Cathedral Choir

TRADITIONAL, TEXT BY SAH D'SIMONE

***Hymn for the Journey**

Diverse in Culture, Nation, Race

TALLIS' CANNON

Diverse in culture, nation, race,
we come together by Your grace.
God, let us be a meeting ground
where hope and healing love are found.

God, let us be a bridge of care
connecting people everywhere.
Help us confront all fear and hate
and lust for power that separate.

When chasms widen, storms arise,
O Holy Spirit, make us wise.
Let our resolve, like steel, be strong
to stand with those who suffer wrong.

God, let us be a table spread
with gifts of love and broken bread,
where all find welcome, grace attends,
and enemies arise as friends.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Fugue in D minor - Reprise (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Inside The Music

“Atahualpa Yupanqui’s “Guitarra dímelo tú” reflects so much of what I’ve been hearing from people recently. The words ask about humanity’s potential to ignore its promise. The singer wants to know why, and asks the guitar for advice. With the final line of the song, Yupanqui reminds us that what sense there is in the world comes through our senses. Within the heaviness of our experiences, we always have the capacity to open ourselves to love, community, the earth, and presence through our senses. Music, the arts, nature, a caring hug, a listening ear, all can be centering. As Robin Wall Kimmerer encourages us in “Braiding Sweetgrass” that Rev. Michael spoke about 2 weeks ago, ceremony gives us a chance to remember to remember. Through sacred time and spaces, we are brought into alignment with our being in ways that help the outside world feel more aligned. Yupanqui’s stirring melody that jolts and pokes in relationship with the words, gets under our skin as the guitar asks questions with each note. The piece continues to tap us on the shoulder, encouraging us to open to ourselves, and to life. That is, surely, the gift of J.S. Bach’s well known “Jesu, Joy.” The unyielding triple lilt in the organ flows us into presence. The choir provides echoes of affirmation that joy, indeed, exists and is here in this moment. We are thrilled to be joined by Michel von Loh again this week who will be accompanying Lorenzo, and also playing two pieces during communion.” -*Dr. David Harris*